

JEFFERSON RODRIGUEZ NAJERA

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EDUCATION

University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA

May 2026

Frank Batten School of Leadership & Public Policy

Master of Public Policy

- GPA: 3.80 out of 4.00
- Awards and Recognitions: Fulbright Scholar, Batten Family Bicentennial Scholars Fellow
- Relevant Coursework: *Research Methods and Data Analysis; Economics; Advanced Topics on Impact Evaluation; Regional Economic Modeling, Development Economics; Leadership in the Public Arena; Development Economics*

University of Costa Rica, San José, Costa Rica

May 2020

School of Public Administration

Licentiate's degree in Public Administration

- GPA: 9.45 out of 10
- Awards and Recognitions: Graduation with an honorific mention
- Relevant Coursework: *Leadership and Decision-making; Research and Knowledge Management; Stakeholders and Conflict Resolution; Challenges of the Public Administration*

Bachelor of Arts in Public Administration

Aug 2018

- GPA 9.03 out of 10
- Awards and Recognitions: Graduation with honorific mention; First Place, XI Congress of Red-e-Mun Student Debate; International speaker at the XI Congress of Red-e-Mun: Local government evaluation
- Relevant Coursework: *Impact Evaluation; General Statistics; Public Resources Management; Public Services Management.*

University of Los Andes, Bogotá, Colombia

Jan – June 2018

- Immersive, semester-long study abroad; International Studies Office Scholarship Award Recipient
- Relevant Coursework: *Introduction to Policy Analysis; The Right to the City; Public Management Practice*

RELEVANT EXPERIENCE

Independent consultant, Charlottesville

Aug 2025 – May 2026

Consultant

- Collaborated in a year-long project with the Costa Rican “Comisión Nacional de Prevención de Riesgos y Atención de Emergencias CNE”, to identify potential alternatives to address displacement and relocation in three communities in Esparza, Puntarenas. Tasks included literature reviews, policy writing, critical analysis, cost-benefit analysis, and results presentation, resulting in a fully drafted consulting technical report with an implementation plan, cost forecasts, and practical tools to adapt the alternatives to different contexts.

The Center for Social Innovation at UVA, Charlottesville

Mar 2025 – May 2026

Research Assistant

- Assisted two research projects focused on development economics in Latin America. Responsibilities include identifying and harmonizing administrative and survey data, cleaning and organizing large datasets, and conducting applied econometric analysis to inform social and economic policy design using Stata and Python. Work involves supporting the design and implementation of empirical strategies, interpreting results, and contributing to research outputs that inform policy discussions on economic development and labor markets in the region.

Costa Rica Judicial Branch, San José

Sep 2021 – Jun 2024

Senior Policy Analyst

- Led the nationwide implementation of an Open Data Protocol, coordinating with high-level public officials and stakeholders to strengthen institutional capacity, transparency, and evidence-based policymaking, resulting in a 100% increase in publicly available datasets, enhancing data availability for social policy analysis, service delivery monitoring, and institutional accountability.
- Designed and executed a pilot project to integrate new sociodemographic variables into administrative systems, improving targeting, inclusiveness, and monitoring of public service delivery for vulnerable populations, resulting in implementation across four offices with over 10,000 weekly users, demonstrating the feasibility of incorporating enhanced data for policy targeting and improved access to public services.

- Directed the expansion of a public service delivery and community-based support program to urban areas by developing a research proposal, mapping territorial needs, and creating a prioritization and targeting methodology, which increased program coverage by 10% and boosted the number of judicial facilitators by 7% within the first six months.

University of Costa Rica, San José

Mar 2016 – Jul 2022

Co-founder and Area Coordinator – “Idea Pública” Innovation Lab (Jun 2018 – July 2022, part time)

- Applied data analysis to develop a methodology for identifying public problems and designing local development, social policy, and service delivery solutions for 15 Costa Rican local governments, conducting literature reviews and overseeing fieldwork with undergraduate students for The Trust for The Americas of the Organization of American States, achieving 100% effectiveness in one year and drafting five new local policies.

Senior Project Manager – Public Administration Research and Training Center (Sept 2019 – Aug 2021, full time)

- Negotiated and managed policy projects for public institutions in regional development, labor force management, and public sector modernization, contributing to mobilizing over USD 1 million in funding for public sector reform and development projects over two years.

Research Assistant – Local Government Development Program (Mar 2016 – Dec 2017, part time)

- Conducted policy analysis, literature reviews, and project coordination to implement initiatives in regional development, local economic development, and employment-related planning.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Virginia, Charlottesville

Jan – May 2026

Teaching Assistant

- Assisted the “Leadership in the Public Arena” course, based on the adaptive leadership framework. Responsibilities included class planning, holding office hours, explaining complex concepts to a broad range of audiences, and other administrative tasks.

University of Costa Rica, San José

Mar 2020 – Jul 2024

Junior Lecturer – School of Public Administration (part time)

- Delivered undergraduate lectures on leadership and ethics, strategic communication, and rural development for Public Administration students, fostering critical thinking and practical application in future public sector leaders.
- Designed research proposals and community engagement projects to foster the international visibility of the School of Public Administration.
- Advised several thesis projects in topics such as local development, public policy, budget analysis, and others.

PUBLICATIONS

Rodríguez-Nájera, J. (2026). From Invisibility to Evidence: Reflections on Inclusive Participatory Data Collection in the Costa Rican Judiciary. *Revista del CLAD Reforma y Democracia*, (95). (Accepted - Pending publication)

Rodríguez Nájera, J.; Barquero Gamboa, C. y Hernández Cruz, O. (2021). Strategic linking of cultural public policies: case analysis of the cantons of Belén, Santa Ana and Escazú. *Compilación Administrar lo Público*, p. 70-82; 9na. Edición; Enero-Diciembre, Vol. 1 Núm 1. ISBN 978-9968-932-41-7, San José, CR. Licencia CC BY 4.

Rodríguez Nájera, J.; Barrantes Herrera, A. y Hurtado Herrera, A. (2020). Cultural public policy implementation: compared study of the management models of Santa Ana, Escazú, and Belén territories. *Universidad de Costa Rica. Facultad de Ciencias Económicas*.

Rodríguez, J; Fernández, C; Calderón, C; Calderón, J & Umaña, J. (2018). Collaboration networks for local innovation. *Organization for American States (OAS), Trust for the Americas, and Innovaap UCR*. San José, Costa Rica.

LEADERSHIP & CIVIC EXPERIENCE

APO FU Foundation, Malawi / San José

Jan 2019 – Jun 2021

Administrative Coordinator

- Directed the creation of a new business model and strategy for operating the educational and fundraising sectors in Costa Rica, resulting in improved resource management and overall performance.

Accion Ciudadana Party, Coronado

Oct 2019 – Feb 2020

Municipal Council Candidate

- Served as a candidate for the Municipal Council, engaging in lobbying, collaborating with local representatives, and designing a comprehensive development plan for my local government.

SKILLS

- Software: *MS Office, Stata (advanced); Tableau, Power BI, and Excel (intermediate); Python, R (basic)*
- Language: *Spanish (native speaker); English (advanced proficiency)*